Topic 42 — International Environmental Organizations

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

UNEP (संयुक्त राष्ट्र पर्यावरण कार्यक्रम) | UNDP (यूएनडीपी) | FAO | UNESCO | IUCN (आईयूसीएन) | WWF (डब्ल्यूडब्ल्यूएफ) | IPCC (आईपीसीसी) | WMO | GEF | Greenpeace

Sources baked in: IPCC AR6; UNEP; UNDP HDR; IUCN Red List; WWF LPR; FAO SOFO; UNESCO WH/MAB; UPPCS PYQs **Weight:** ★★★ High — org ↔ report; HQ traps; IUCN≠CITES; IPCC≠UNFCCC **Last verified:** August 2026

Current Affairs (this topic)

- UNEP / IUCN / IPCC / GEF role headlines refresh institutional CA.
- HQ and mandate traps stay fixed teaching.

42.1 UNEP

Identity: Stockholm 1972 | Nairobi | Emissions Gap | GEO | Treaty host

- **UNEP (United Nations Environment Programme)** is the UN's principal environment coordination body, created after the **Stockholm Conference (1972)** (स्टॉकहोम सम्मेलन).
- **HQ: Nairobi, Kenya** — not Geneva or New York.
- Publishes the annual **Emissions Gap Report** (NDC shortfall vs 1.5–2°C pathways) and **GEO (Global Environment Outlook)**.
- Hosts/supports secretariats for treaties such as Montreal, Basel, Stockholm POPs, and Minamata.
- Co-created **IPCC** with WMO, but Emissions Gap is **UNEP's own** report.
- **GEF (Global Environment Facility, 1991)** finances projects under major environment conventions; UNEP is an implementing agency. Donors are **not** "developed countries only."
- GEF serves as a financial mechanism for five major conventions: **Minamata**, **Stockholm POPs**, **CBD**, **UNCCD**, and **UNFCCC**.
- Core implementing partners include **UNDP**, **UNEP**, and the **World Bank**.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2024, Q6

Emissions Gap Report publisher among org–report match:

Show answer

UNEP — Full key: HDR→UNDP, WEO→IMF, WIR→UNCTAD, Emissions Gap→**UNEP** → **A (3 1 4 2)**.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2025, Q145

GEF: (1) established 1991 (2) only developed countries are donors

Options: A. Only 2 B. Neither C. Both D. Only 1

Show answer

Ans: D — Year true; donor statement false.

> **Logic:** Emissions Gap ≠ IPCC Assessment Report.

42.2 UNDP

Identity: New York | HDR 1990 | HDI | Mahbub ul Haq + Amartya Sen | SDGs

- **UNDP (United Nations Development Programme)** is the UN's development network agency.
- **HQ: New York**.
- Publishes the **Human Development Report (HDR)** and **Human Development Index (HDI)** since **1990**.
- HDI was developed by **Mahbub ul Haq** with conceptual contribution from **Amartya Sen** — not a "Priesner-led" first team.
- Supports country-level **SDG** implementation; environment enters via sustainable development programming.
- Not the publisher of Emissions Gap, Red List, or Living Planet Report.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2025, Q132

1. UNDP published first HDR in 1990 with HDI.
2. First HDI team led by Mahbub-ul-Haq and S. Priesner.

Options: A. Only 2 B. Neither C. Both D. Only 1

Show answer

Ans: D — Stmt 1 true; stmt 2 false (Haq–Sen lineage, not Priesner).

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2018, Q35

HDI was first developed by:

Options: A. UNDP B. IMF C. UNICEF D. UNCTAD

Show answer

Ans: A

> **Logic:** UNDP ≠ UNEP. HDR ≠ Emissions Gap.

42.3 FAO

Identity: Rome | Food–agriculture–forests | SOFO | Rotterdam with UNEP

- **FAO (Food and Agriculture Organization)** is the UN specialised agency for food and agriculture.
- **HQ: Rome, Italy**.
- Environment role: agriculture–forest–biodiversity–land-use links; pesticide and forestry governance.
- Co-publishes **State of the World's Forests (SOFO)** with UNEP.
- Jointly administers the **Rotterdam Convention** (PIC for hazardous chemicals in trade) with **UNEP**.
- Not the publisher of HDR, Emissions Gap, or Red List.

> **Logic:** FAO HQ = **Rome**, not Nairobi.

42.4 UNESCO

Identity: Paris | World Heritage | MAB Biosphere Reserves (जैवमंडल आरक्षित क्षेत्र) | ESD

- **UNESCO** leads education, science, and culture — environment enters via heritage and biosphere programmes.
- **HQ: Paris**.
- Designates **UNESCO World Heritage Sites** (natural/cultural/mixed) under the 1972 WH Convention.
- Runs the **Man and the Biosphere (MAB)** programme — World Network of Biosphere Reserves.
- Supports Education for Sustainable Development (ESD).
- **Limits to Growth** is **Club of Rome**, not UNESCO.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2019, Q35

Jaipur listed as UNESCO World Heritage Site at the 43rd session (पंगु सत्र) held in:

Options: A. Baku B. Bishkek C. Istanbul D. Marrakesh

Show answer

Ans: A (Baku)

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2019, Q146

"Limits to Growth" propounded by:

Options: A. Club of Rome B. UNESCO C. Brundtland D. Agenda 21

Show answer

Ans: A

> **Logic:** UNESCO = WH/MAB. UNEP = environment programme.

42.5 IUCN

Identity: 1948 | Gland | Red List | Assess risk ≠ regulate trade

- **IUCN (International Union for Conservation of Nature)** is a global conservation union of governments and NGOs, founded **1948**.
- **HQ: Gland, Switzerland**.
- Publishes the **IUCN Red List** of extinction risk (LC, NT, VU, EN, CR, EW, EX).
- **Threatened** categories commonly = **VU + EN + CR**.
- Assesses scientific extinction risk; does **not** regulate wildlife trade — **CITES** does.
- Advises CBD/CITES scientifically but is a separate organisation.

> **Logic:** "IUCN bans trade" = false. **CITES** regulates trade.

42.6 WWF

Identity: Conservation NGO | Gland | Living Planet Report | Panda logo

- **WWF (World Wide Fund for Nature)** is a global conservation **NGO**, not a UN agency.
- Since **1961**, WWF's logo animal has been the **Giant Panda (*Ailuropoda melanoleuca*)**.
- It publishes the **Living Planet Report** and Living Planet Index.
- **HQ: Gland, Switzerland** — same city as IUCN, different organisation.
- Publishes the **Living Planet Report** and **Living Planet Index (LPI)** on vertebrate population (जनसंख्या) trends.
- Known for the **giant panda** logo and flagship-species campaigns.
- Campaigns and advocates; IUCN assesses via Red List.

> **Logic:** Living Planet = **WWF**. Red List = **IUCN**.

42.7 IPCC

Identity: 1988 WMO+UNEP | Geneva | Assessment Reports | Science ≠ policy

- **IPCC (Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (जलवायु परिवर्तन))** was established in **1988** by **WMO** and **UNEP**.

- **HQ: Geneva**.
- Publishes **Assessment Reports** (AR1→AR6; AR6 synthesis **2023**) plus special reports.
- Synthesises existing science; does **not** set NDCs or negotiate treaties.
- Shared the **Nobel Peace Prize 2007** with Al Gore.
- **UNFCCC/COP** is the policy–treaty track; IPCC informs it.

> **Logic:** IPCC ≠ UNFCCC. IPCC ≠ Emissions Gap Report.

42.8 WMO, Greenpeace & US EPA

Identity: WMO Geneva | Greenpeace Amsterdam | US EPA 1970

- The **World Meteorological Organization (WMO)** (डब्लूएमओ) provides the global framework for meteorology and operational hydrology.
- WMO originated from the **International Meteorological Organization (1873)** and became WMO on **17 March 1951**.
- **WMO headquarters is Geneva, Switzerland.** It co-created the **IPCC** with UNEP in **1988**.
- **Greenpeace International** is an environmental NGO headquartered in **Amsterdam, Netherlands**.
- The **US Environment Protection Agency (EPA)** was established on **2 December 1970** to write and enforce environmental health regulations in the United States.
- Do not confuse the **US EPA** with India's **Environment (Protection) Act, 1986**.

Body	HQ / year	Job
WMO	Geneva	Weather/climate cooperation; IPCC parent
Greenpeace	Amsterdam	Environmental NGO
US EPA	Est. 1970	US federal environment agency
UNEP	Nairobi	UN environment programme

Org ↔ Report ↔ HQ Card

Org	HQ	Flagship fact
UNEP	Nairobi	Emissions Gap / GEO
UNDP	New York	HDR / HDI
FAO	Rome	SOFO; Rotterdam (+UNEP)
UNESCO	Paris	World Heritage; MAB
IUCN	Gland	Red List

Org	HQ	Flagship fact
WWF	Gland	Living Planet
IPCC	Geneva	Assessment Reports
WMO	Geneva	Meteorology; IPCC co-parent
Greenpeace	Amsterdam	Environmental NGO

42.8 OPCW & UN-Habitat (bank add-ons)

Identity: Chemical Weapons Convention | The Hague | Habitat (वास स्थान) Nairobi

- **OPCW (Organisation for the Prohibition (प्रतिषेध) of Chemical Weapons)** implements the **Chemical Weapons Convention** (force **29 April 1997**); HQ **The Hague**, Netherlands. It verifies destruction/non-re-emergence of chemical weapons and assists states against chemical threats — **not** an EU/NATO/WHO body. Nobel Peace Prize **2013**.
- **UN-Habitat** (UN Human Settlements Programme; HQ **Nairobi**, from **1978**) is mandated to promote socially and environmentally sustainable towns/cities and adequate shelter; partners include governments, local authorities, and non-state actors; contributes to poverty reduction and safe water/sanitation access. Partners are **not** governments-only.

> **Logic:** OPCW ≠ EU organ. UN-Habitat partners ≠ governments only.